

My work uses an interactive form to create poetry through words from other people's love letters. This project disrupts the intended meaning of words, giving them purpose in the hands of the user. Without context, the user derives their own meaning from the words and creates a Frankenstein'd poem that holds meaning only to them. The caveat being that the user has no control of the words they can use.

Inspired by William Burroughs, "The Cut Up Method," and Jacquelyn Ardam's, "The ABCs of Conceptual Writing," I decided to tackle my cynicism headon by engaging with the methods of the medium. The quote, "[the] best writing seems to be done almost by accident but writers until the cut up method was made explicit-- (all writing is in fact cut ups. I will return to this point)--had no way to produce the accident of spontaneity" (Burroughs, 2020) was the cornerstone for the constraints I abided by while working through this project. By limiting the user to only a handful of words, they have to make meaningful choices when engaging with this piece. But this also takes some pressure off of the user, when they aren't in control of what comes next, their writing is liberated. I return spontaneity to the user.

Mimicking the structure of blackout poetry, I focus the user's attention on their actions. All elements must be placed thoughtfully, will they focus form over meaning or meaning over form? Ordering the wordpool alphabetically was inspired by the idea of having "an arbitrary list of context-less language" (Ardam, 2014) to create meaning ex nihilo, but also added a unique layer to the constraints. Pulling from random love letters and singling out unique words from each created a heat map of frequently used initials, meaning the user may have a dozen 's' words to use and only one 'v.' This limitation is purposeful. The more options the user has, the more diluted the content becomes.

A poem composed of my own words is connected thoroughly by the meaning I've assigned to each word. When that connection is disrupted, a more thoughtful arrangement forms. This project exposes creativity, that even when the tools are limited its potential is boundless. Removing my own input from the final product is intentional, I give power to the user who is now both the reader and the artist. They form a solitary bond with the words they choose, demonstrating that a word's meaning is assigned by the beholder.

References

Ardam, J. (2014). The ABCs of Conceptual Writing. *Comparative Literature Studies*, 51(1),

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Burroughs, W. (2020). The cut up method. In *Upenn.edu*.

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